

John Lapinski

DW-NOMINATE critique, and where it meets UVote's alignment scores

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One page

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Not verified as Penn political science department chair — his CV lists "Undergraduate Chair" (2009–15), a teaching-committee role, not the department chair. Use the roles above, not that title.

WHERE HIS WORK ALREADY VALIDATES UVOTE

His career thesis is your product

The Substance of Representation argues representation should be judged by what legislators actually do, not party label or perception. UVote's Constituent/District/Representation scores are a live, applied version of that argument — for a level of government (city councils) his own field has never had the data to study this way.

You already built the caution he'd ask for

His DW-NOMINATE critique is fundamentally about statistical honesty at small sample sizes. UVote's own "rigor over sentiment" principle — minimum vote thresholds, abstentions excluded — is the same instinct, arrived at independently before either side knew of the other's work.

PUSHBACKS TO PREPARE FOR

Is the alignment score one blended number, or issue-level?

CONCRETE PATH EXISTS

BATEMAN & LAPINSKI (2016), TABLE 1

Sen. Fulbright ranks 4th-most-liberal Democrat on DW-NOMINATE's blended score, but 13th on international affairs and 42nd on domestic policy — the single score erases a real, important split.

Today it's one blended number, not issue-disaggregated — say so plainly. **Frame it as validation, not a gap he caught you on:** bills are already tagged by topic (Housing, Public Safety, Budget, etc.), so issue-level scoring isn't a from-scratch build. Good opening to invite him to help design it.

Is the score a flat career average, or weighted toward recent votes?

DESIGN QUESTION FOR FUTURE

BATEMAN & LAPINSKI (2016), §2.1 – REP. JAMIE WHITTEN

DW-NOMINATE's linear-trend assumption forces a whole career onto one straight line — flattening Whitten's real shift from 1941 segregationist to 1980s Reagan-opposing liberal.

No weighting today — an unweighted average. **Name the parallel directly:** averaging a rep's whole voting history risks the same problem his Whitten example shows. Turn it into a real question for him: how do you weight recency toward fairness without making it easy to game by "converting" right before a review period?

Does the score account for what leadership brings to a vote?

DOCUMENTED LIMITATION

BATEMAN & LAPINSKI (2016), §2.3 – SOCIAL SECURITY, 1935–2003

Successive real benefit liberalizations don't show up as a consistent leftward score movement — agenda effects (what comes to a vote) can look identical to ideology shifting.

Agreed — a fair critique. State it plainly as a known limitation: the Constituent Score can only measure alignment on bills that reach a floor vote, so it can't separate genuine disagreement from an agenda a rep never controlled. Worth writing into the product's own documentation, not just saying if asked.

WORTH RAISING, NOT A PUSHBACK

Non-partisan-by-architecture, vs. his realignment research

OPEN DISCUSSION

UVote hides party affiliation to avoid priming. His other book, *Southern Nation*, is about how party realignment actually happens historically — he's unusually well placed to have a real opinion on whether hiding the label removes bias or just relocates it. Treat as a genuine open conversation, not something to defend.

RECOMMENDED ENGAGEMENT PATH

- 1. Now:** a low-cost ask for a methodological review of the alignment-score design — the three points above are the concrete agenda.
- 2. Later, contingent:** re-approach specifically for a DW-NOMINATE-style scoring feature once PA House/Senate or a mature Council dataset exists.
- 3. Only after 1–2:** ask permission to name him in fundraising materials.
- 4. Hold:** a paid advisory retainer, until a concrete deliverable justifies it.

SOURCES

- Bateman, D. A., & Lapinski, J. S. (2016). "Ideal Points and American Political Development: Beyond DW-NOMINATE." *Studies in American Political Development*, 30(2), 147–171.
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- Bateman, Katznelson, & Lapinski (2018). *Southern Nation*. Princeton University Press.
- Clinton, Jackman, & Rivers (2004). "The Statistical Analysis of Roll Call Data." *APSR*, 98(2).

Full write-up: docs/research/academic/lapinski-deep-dive.md – github.com/parnelli32/UVote_May_2026/pull/1